

Wisconsin - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Adequate Power 4 / fringe-bowl quality built around a potentially strong defense, with a much larger offensive range because the quarterback, skill group and line are being reassembled.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 53
Returning production	59% (No. 38) overall · Off. 61% (No. 44) · Def. 57% (No. 49)
Primer power rating	+4.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.7 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better overall, mostly because the offense has a plausible functional reset while the defense should remain the team's strength
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Wisconsin wants a physical, run-led OC Jeff Grimes offense around QB Colton Joseph and a deeper RB room. DC Mike Tressel's defense remains the stronger side behind LB Mason Posa, but OL/WR/secondary turnover drives volatility.

Bottom line: A strong defensive model and upgraded offensive talent create a bowl path, but the No. 53 overall rating hides a major offense/defense split and heavy newcomer dependence.

Beats expectations if: QB Joseph gives Grimes a competent dual-threat engine, RB Sama/RB Dupree make the run game reliable, the OL gets Heywood/Mandell healthy enough to settle a best five, and Tressel's rebuilt front/secondary preserve the defense's explosive-play prevention.

Disappoints if: the OL health problems persist, receiver hierarchy never produces reliable separation, QB Joseph's jump in competition exposes the offense again, and the secondary cannot replace CB Hallman/CB Fourqurean/S Brown while the front loses too much professional departures.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Colton Joseph is Wisconsin's current QB1, with Ryan Hopkins and Deuce Adams competing only for the backup role.
- 2 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense finished No.135 nationally in both scoring (12.8 pts/g) and total offense (253.1 yds/g), while the defense finished No.24 in total defense and No.15 against the run.
- 3 National baseline:** SP+ still sees a large 2026 split: Wisconsin is No.53 overall, No.100 on offense and No.20 on defense.
- 4 ★ LB Mason Posa:** LB Mason Posa appears on the Bednarik and Butkus watchlists and is the clearest inside-linebacker anchor.
- 5 ◆ Roster overhaul:** The roster reset is enormous: 33 incoming transfers plus major professional losses, and the OL/corner/specialist order remains unsettled entering the season.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (2-7 Big Ten)	● Poor
Scoring	12.8 PPG	● Very poor
Total offense	253.1 YPG	● Very poor
Rush offense	116.7 YPG · 3.3 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	6.02 YPA · 9 TD / 13 INT	● Very poor
Third downs	32.3%	● Very poor
Scoring defense	21.6 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	323.5 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	105.2 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	218.2 YPG · 7.61 YPA · 19 TD allowed	● Poor

The offense was among the nation’s worst across scoring, yardage and passing efficiency. The defense kept Wisconsin competitive, especially against the run.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-2.70 · No. 89	● Below average
Off. EPA/play	-0.084 · No. 103	● Below average
Off. success rate	36.9% · No. 122	● Very poor
Off. explosive-play rate	8.5% · No. 133	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	17.0% · No. 107	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+2.64 · No. 40	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.086 · No. 33	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	45.2% · No. 119	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.5% · No. 37	● Good / above average
Havoc created	13.4% · No. 110	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: The offense was poor in EPA, success rate and explosiveness. The defense was much better by EPA/adjusted ratings and explosive prevention, though weak success-rate defense and havoc show it was more resistant than disruptive.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Luke Fickell - returning	● ↔ Continuity helps a major roster reset
OC	Jeff Grimes - returning; offensive play-caller	● ↑ Year-two continuity plus a dual-threat QB fit
DC	Mike Tressel - returning; defensive play-caller	● ↔ Same caller; personnel replacement is the larger issue

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Colton Joseph	Old Dominion	● ↑ Dual-threat QB1 for a badly needed offensive reset.
◆ RB Abu Sama III	Iowa State	● ↑ Proven production and a lead/co-lead role.
◆ WR Jaylon Domingeaux	Southeastern Louisiana	● ↔ Most productive incoming WR; order remains open.
◆ OL PJ Wilkins	Ole Miss	● ↔ Adds experience to the best-five/tackle mix.
◆ OL Austin Kawecki	Oklahoma State	● ↔ Interior/center candidate in the rebuilt five.

Out	To	Loss
QB Billy Edwards Jr.	North Carolina	● ↔ Starting QB departs, offset by QB Colton Joseph's arrival.
OL Riley Mahlman	NFL (Atlanta), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran starting tackle leaves.
OL Joe Brunner	Indiana	● ↓ Major OL contributor deepens the rebuild.
OL Jake Renfro	Illinois	● ↓ Further reduces OL continuity.
WR Vinny Anthony II	NFL (Atlanta), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material receiving contributor exits.

Offensive net: ● ↑ higher upside at quarterback/running back but materially lower shared continuity, especially on the offensive line.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Jacob Anderson	Illinois State	● ↔ Productive transfer projects to a major role.
◆ DL Junior Poyser	Buffalo	● ↔ Adds proven pass-rush production.
◆ S Marvin Burks Jr.	Missouri	● ↔ Veteran starter stabilizes safety.
◆ CB Javan Robinson	Arizona State	● ↔ Leading corner candidate in a rebuilt room.

Out	To	Loss
CB Ricardo Hallman	NFL (Denver), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran corner with 38 consecutive starts departs.
CB Nyzier Fourqurean	NFL (L.A. Rams), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Major starting corner exits.
S Austin Brown	NFL (Indianapolis), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material starting safety exits.
DL Ben Barten	NFL (N.Y. Giants), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 12-game starter leaves via a Giants UDFA path.
DL Jay'Viarr Suggs	NFL (New Orleans), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 11-start defensive lineman leaves via a Saints UDFA path.

Defensive net: ● ↓ worse continuity with enough transfer talent and returning linebacker/safety anchors to preserve an above-average ceiling.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Physical, run-led OC Jeff Grimes attack with a dual-threat QB and deeper backfield.	QB Colton Joseph plus RB Abu Sama III/RB Darrion Dupree.	OL health/cohesion and unsettled WR hierarchy.
Defense	DC Mike Tressel unit built around LB Mason Posa and a transfer-heavy front.	Strong 2025 EPA, adjusted defense, rush defense and explosive prevention.	Low disruption plus major DL/CB/S departures.
Special teams	Personnel-reset unit with little job certainty.	Incoming options are present at punter and long snapper.	All primary specialist roles are being re-established, and SP+ ranks the unit only No.97.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	QB Colton Joseph fits the scheme but is new to Power 4 play.
RB	● B–	● ↑	Medium-high	RB Sama and RB Dupree give Wisconsin two credible lead options.
WR	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	More options and transfer production, but no closed order or proven Power 4 alpha.
TE	● C+	● ↔	Medium	Functional competition without a proven high-end centerpiece.
OL	● C	● ↓	Low	The best five is both rebuilt and health-dependent.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Credible transfers replace a large NFL departure class.
LB	● B+	● ↑	High	LB Posa is a high-end anchor with proven LB Catalano support.
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Safety has credible anchors, but corner is a major rebuild.
Special teams	● C	● ↓	Low	Multiple specialist jobs reset at once.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	High	Full coordinator/caller continuity raises scheme confidence even after a poor offensive year.
Overall	● B–	● ↑	Medium-low	Adequate Power 4 profile driven by defense; offensive and portal volatility prevent a stronger grade.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Colton Joseph (TR: Old Dominion)	QB	● Unproven Power 4 starter / system-fit dual threat	-	Central variable in lifting the No. 135 scoring/yardage offense.
Mason Posa	LB	● High-end conference defender / defensive anchor	Bednarik watchlist · Butkus watchlist	The clearest returning star on the team and the centerpiece of the defense's strongest position group.
◆ Abu Sama III (TR: Iowa State)	RB	● Above-average conference lead-back candidate	-	Proven production gives Wisconsin a credible lead option.
Darrion Dupree	RB	● Functional-to-above-average conference rotation back	-	Returning 2025 team-leading rusher pairs with Sama to keep the run game from depending on one newcomer.
◆ Jaylon Domingeaux (TR: Southeastern Louisiana)	WR	● High-upside transfer receiver	-	Best proven production profile among incoming WRs.
Sebastian Cheeks	OLB	● Established conference edge starter	-	Returning edge reference after 25 tackles, three sacks and 5.5 TFL in 2025 amid major NFL turnover.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Matthew Jung	S	● Established conference starter / secondary anchor	-	Returns after eight starts and 50 tackles and supplies needed continuity behind a rebuilt corner room.
◆ Marvin Burks Jr. (TR: Missouri)	S	● Solid Power 4 veteran starter projection	-	Twenty-six consecutive starts stabilize safety.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	A medium-hard schedule with a brutal upper tier but enough mid-tier swing games to make bowl eligibility realistic if the offense becomes functional.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 37
Hardest stretch	at Penn State → Michigan State → bye → at UCLA → USC → at Iowa
Swing games	Michigan State, at UCLA, Rutgers, at Maryland, at Purdue, Minnesota
Advantage	Western Illinois and Eastern Michigan create two home reset games after the Notre Dame opener, and the mid-November run contains several opponents close to Wisconsin in SP+ rating.
Expected	5.7 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The brand can attract respect, but a better record can come from converting the mid-tier swing games without proving Wisconsin is fully restored. Seven wins still requires the defense to stay high-end while the rebuilt offense becomes dependable.
Back them when	Against comparable teams when QB Joseph and the OL are healthy enough to support the run game and the matchup allows Tressel's defense to control explosives rather than chase elite passing offenses.
Fade/pass when	When the offensive line is compromised, Wisconsin must win through obvious passing downs, or the rebuilt corners face high-end vertical receivers before the new order has proven stable.
Key monitor	Kevin Heywood availability, Emerson Mandell availability, final OL five, receiver hierarchy, cornerback order, specialist winners, QB Joseph transition to Power 4 competition
Week 1 baseline	Wisconsin +22.5 vs. Notre Dame (neutral) · rating-only baseline; Wisconsin primer +4.0 minus Notre Dame primer +26.5; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Wisconsin +20.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Wisconsin does not need an elite offense to improve sharply from 4-8. QB Colton Joseph and RB Abu Sama III give OC Jeff Grimes a plausible run-game reset, but the rebuilt OL and WR hierarchy must become functional after one of FBS's worst offensive seasons.

LB Mason Posa leads a defense that should remain the stronger unit despite heavy front/secondary turnover. **5.7 wins and 6-6** is a reasonable bowl-line baseline, with a wide range because so many important roles depend on newcomers.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaches](#) · [QB Colton Joseph](#) · [fall camp](#) · [defensive outlook](#) · [offensive play-calling](#) · [NFL exits](#)

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